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The first individual a person meets after exiting his or her house.

A wandering fjord.

This reclassification has implications for conservation. If there are two separate species, each will be less abundant and could be more endangered than a more numerous and wide ranging single species. Conversely, there is also a potential danger that, if the forest elephant is not explicitly listed as an endangered species, poachers and smugglers might be able to evade the law forbidding trade in endangered animals and their products.

The Forest elephant and the Savanna elephant can also hybridise interbreed though their preferences for different terrains reduce such opportunities. As the African elephant has only recently been recognized to comprise two separate species, groups of captive elephants have not been comprehensively classified and some could well be hybrids.

The species of elephants are typically greyish in colour, but the Africans very often appear brown or reddish from wallowing in mud holes of coloured soil. Wallowing is an important behaviour in elephant society. Not only is it important for socialization, but the mud acts as a sunscreen, protecting their skin from harsh ultraviolet radiation. Although tough, an elephants skin is very sensitive. Without regular mud baths to protect it from burning, as well as from insect bites and moisture loss, an elephants skin would suffer serious damage. After bathing, the elephant will usually use its trunk to blow dirt on its body to help dry and bake on its new protective coat. As elephants are limited to smaller and smaller areas, there is less water available, and local herds will often come too close over the right to use these limited resources.

Wallowing also aids the skin in regulating body temperatures. Elephants have difficulty in releasing heat through the skin because, in proportion to their body size, they have very little of it. The ratio of an elephants mass to the surface area of its skin is many times that of a human. Elephants have even been observed lifting up their legs to expose the soles of their feet, presumably in an effort to expose more skin to the air. Since wild elephants live in very hot climates, they must have other means of getting rid of excess heat. An elephants legs are great straight pillars, as they must be to support its bulk. The elephant needs less muscular power to stand because of its straight legs and large padlike feet. For this reason an elephant can stand for very long periods of time without tiring.